

# Coping strategies for surviving the wait, grounding techniques, managing catastrophic thinking — Action Checklist

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## REGULATE YOUR NERVOUS SYSTEM

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- ☐ **Regulate Your Nervous System:** Recognize that catastrophic thoughts are a body problem, not a thinking problem, so stop trying to think your way out of panic and start regulating your way through it instead.
- ☐ **Regulate Your Nervous System:** Sit down and plant your feet firmly on the floor before any anxiety-management technique, because feeling the ground beneath you creates an immediate safety signal for your nervous system.
- ☐ **Regulate Your Nervous System:** Understand that your prefrontal cortex goes partially offline during high anxiety, which is why rational thinking fails during panic spirals and why you need body-based tools, not just mental ones.
- ☐ **Regulate Your Nervous System:** Create a daily practice of breathing and grounding techniques when you are calm, so your body builds the neural pathways it needs to access regulation tools automatically during a crisis.

## PRACTICE THE 4-4-4 RESET

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- ☐ **Practice the 4-4-4 Reset:** Breathe in through your nose for exactly four counts, hold for four counts, then exhale through your mouth for four counts, because the slow extended exhale directly activates your parasympathetic nervous system.
- ☐ **Practice the 4-4-4 Reset:** Count out loud or track each breath on your fingers while breathing, because counting creates a tactile neural anchor that prevents your brain from catastrophizing simultaneously.
- ☐ **Practice the 4-4-4 Reset:** When your mind wanders to worst-case scenarios mid-breath, simply notice it without judgment and redirect back to counting, because getting pulled away is not a failure but part of the practice.
- ☐ **Practice the 4-4-4 Reset:** Use the 4-4-4 breathing before checking your phone for test results, at 2am when you wake up spiraling, and in the waiting room before your name is called, because these are your highest-risk moments.

## USE RAPID GROUNDING DAILY

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- ☐ **Use Rapid Grounding Daily:** Name five things you can see out loud in your immediate environment, speaking rather than thinking silently, because using your voice grounds you more effectively than silent observation.

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  - ☐ **Use Rapid Grounding Daily:** Identify and physically engage with four things you can touch right now, pressing your feet into the floor and noting textures on your clothing, because physical sensation anchors you in present reality.

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  - ☐ **Use Rapid Grounding Daily:** Practice the rapid 5-4-3-2-1 sequence in 60 to 90 seconds when you feel a spiral starting, because speed matters more than thoroughness when you need to interrupt anxiety before it accelerates.

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  - ☐ **Use Rapid Grounding Daily:** Keep your grounding toolkit deployable at all times by knowing your specific sensory anchors ahead of time, so you can yank yourself back to present reality at 2am when your hands are shaking.
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Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.